Deus-X

By Jules Tasca

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: Why are some people extremely religious, others are "luke-warm" or "born-again" believers and still others fall into the categories of agnostic, atheist, or religious fanatic?

ACTOR: Wars are fought, people die in the battle over religious superiority. Muslims, Jews, Christians . . . . In the name of God . . . . when will it end?

ACTRESS: Or where does it start? Is belief in God a learned personality trait, or are we somehow genetically predisposed to our faith. Do we inherit it like we inherit our risk of diabetes or cancer?

ACTOR: And if so . . . the scientific mind asks . . . can religiosity be treated, be cured, even . . . . . eliminated? No wars, no terrorist bombings, no radiation, no chemotherapy . . . perhaps just a simple pill. . . A pill called Deus-X by Jules Tasca.

Lights come up on FANNY MAE SPIELER, a conservatively dressed woman. She addresses the audience.

FANNY: I've come here today to the laboratory of my brother-in-law, Doctor Albert Spieler, in order to save my marriage. [ALBERT SPIELER, a man in a lab coat, appears.] This man, this tool of all that is evil in the world, has ruined my marriage...

ALBERT: At least let me tell my own side, Fanny Mae. Fanny Mae is married to my brother.

FANNY: The Reverend Gerald Spieler...

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ALBERT: Gerry... my brother and I were brought up in the same home. We had the same upbringing. [ALBERT mimics his parents]

MALE VOICE: One more report card from school like this and I'm gonna take my strap off!

FEMALE VOICE: No more giggling in there, Albert! Gerry! It's 11 o'clock.

MALE VOICE: Put that dog out or I'll put you out!

FEMALE VOICE: I don't care if you do hate his guts. He's your brother, so shake hands!

ALBERT: You get the idea. It was a typical American family. Gerry and I were both loved and beaten equally. The mystery is how Gerry grew up to be ...The Reverend Gerald Spieler, Jesus' four-star general here on earth. . .

FANNY: An evangelist to all mankind.

ALBERT: And I, Albert Spieler, grew up to be ...

FANNY: A little liberal, atheistic, materialistic, anti-Christ, medical doctor!

ALBERT: It astounded me that I went off to college to become a scientist and Gerry...

FANNY: Graduated with honors from the Midwest Theological Seminary in Nebraska.

ALBERT: Then he started a church...And married adorable her, a minister's daughter.

FANNY: What a team we made. Gerald went on to become the leading Televangelist in America. "Jesus', General" the program was called. We were seen in all 50 states and were ready to go world wide until. . .

ALBERT: I began this special research. Why, I thought, do some people become so ensconced in religion, while in others, religion simply, as in the case of vaccination, does not take. Regardless of how bombarded I was with religious teaching - from Noah's ark to Lazarus' double dip at living - I could never

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regard religion as anything more than bunkum and scarum and hocum. But my brother...

FANNY: Gerald actually spoke with Jesus! Why, Gerald and Jesus were like Mutt and Jeff.

ALBERT: While Gerry took production meetings with Jesus, I studied over 100 families where some of the members of a family were religious, but had brothers or sisters who were not. Ergo, I postulated a theory that, since no environmental factors could account for religion taking in one sibling and not taking in another, there must be some biochemical entity in the brain stem that is different in the religious and the non-religious. It took years of dissection and investigatory surgery. I autopsied over 300 brains whose histories I could verify. I knew which brains were religious and which were not. What I found was this. [He pulls down a medical chart of the brain.]

FANNY: It is disgusting to show something like this in public!

ALBERT: There is a heretofore undiscovered gland the size of a pinhead under the hypothalamus here. In those who are bound by religion, it is visible to the human eye. In those who go to church on high holidays, or, say, only for funerals or a feel-good Christmas experience, it is visible with magnification. In the non-religious, the gland is almost non-existent.

FANNY: Who would believe this?! God is not a gland! He is the Lord!

ALBERT: Everybody said... But I worked with several other leading brain surgeons who corroborated my findings. More years of study and research and I discovered a powerful drug that would shrink this Deus or God gland, as I did so call it. [He holds up a small red pill.] I call the drug... Deus-X.

FANNY: Oh, it's wrong. It is so wrong.

ALBERT: Deus-X is a substance that eliminates the small pin-head gland that makes one's emotions susceptible to religiosity. It impedes the bio-chemicals that

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make the gland thrive. With Deus-X, the gland just withers away and drops off. One dose. One hundred milligrams. That's all it takes.

FANNY: Moral castration! That's what it is, moral castration.

ALBERT: Fanny thinks I developed Deus-X because I hated what my brother Gerry became.

FANNY: Why was one of the first human tests done on a death row prisoner whom Gerald had brought back to Jesus?

ALBERT: Wild Man Cody had killed his whole family of eight with knives and a gun, before the police captured him. Only his grandmother, Granny Lucy, was unscathed that day, because she was having a hip operation. When Wild Man Cody found out that he missed one member of his family... he escaped from jail, went to the hospital, and strangled Granny Lucy in the intensive care unit. Then, his life's work done, he gave himself up.

FANNY: Gerald spent hundreds of hours praying with Mr. Cody...until... poooof! Jesus flamed in his heart. Mr. Cody became born again and allowed Jesus to spin the wheel of his destiny. He said so freely.

ALBERT: Yes. The other death-row prisoners got so sick of listening to Wild Man that they all petitioned to have their execution dates pushed up. [Albert mimics the jailhouse conversation]

WILD MAN: I am not afraid to die and neither should any of you others!

MALE VOICE: Give it a rest, Cody!

WILD MAN: I love those I stabbed. I love those I shot. I love Granny Lucy who I choked. I love the police who arrested me. I love the warden here. I love the press reporters who wrote I should die. Also, I love the executioner who will pop the lethal injection into my arm. I want to be

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executed. I really crave it. I do. You all know why? Because I want to repose with the Lord Jesus for eternity. I'm coming, Jesus! I'm coming! Won't be long!

MALE VOICE: Somebody shut him up! This is cruel and unusual punishment!

ALBERT: In this same spirit of love, Wild Man Cody allowed me, under the prisoner medication testing program, to administer 100 milligrams of Deus-X to him.

FANNY: Gerald and I, as Mr. Cody's spiritual advisors, had no objection. We believed the drug would do nothing to diminish the purification that Gerald had wrought.

ALBERT: But minutes after taking the dosage of Deus-X. . . [ALBERT plays the role of WILDMAN] [Standing and rattling his bars.] I'm glad I killed my whole family! I hated them! They hated me! We hated each other! On Christmas morning, we spat on each other! The Codys were always honest! You know the thrill of seein' your loved ones gunned down? Huh? Killing Granny Lucy was best of all! She couldn't cook! Couldn't sew! And when you went near her, she stunk of old age! I hadda hold my friggin' breath when I strangled her! I hated her! I hate you! All of you!

FANNY: Was it really the effect of Deus-X?

ALBERT: Yes. But one more illustration lest you think that Wild Man Cody was an anomalous fluke.

FANNY: At that time, Gerald and I still didn't believe in Deus-X.

ALBERT: It was science and religion head to head. And Fanny and Gerry were looking bad. While all the medical men and women in the world rushed to lionize me, religious groups, one after another, challenged me. Challenged Deus-X. I turned a whole seminary into circus performers. Large convents were left abandoned, habits strewn on the floors. Synagogues were converted into

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supermarkets. Muslims tried to kill me for transforming one of their holy men into a jockey. .. I made the cover of Newsweek twice!

FANNY: It was sibling rivalry, that's all! You were trying to out-do a more famous brother. Gerald had planned to run for the Presidency of the United States, until... until...

ALBERT: One night on his T.V. program, when Gerry was half crazed with belief in his powers to invoke the aid of the deity, my brother voiced before the whole nation...

FANNY: Ladies and Gentlemen, please welcome Jesus' General here on earth, The Reverend Gerald Spieler!

ALBERT AS GERALD: [Entering with his Bible to loud applause.] Welcome! Welcome, Brothers and Sisters in Christ! Praise God! And welcome to the Lord's very own T.V. program. You all know why we're here tonight. I hold in my right hand the Book of Light, and in my left hand I hold 100 milligrams of the substance that my devil-driven brother calls Deus-X. Yes, it is the real thing. I asked him to come here tonight and place the pill in this hand, so he could not say we substituted an M & M for this... this X .. . Yes, X. Ex. Extinguish. Expunge. Extirpate. Exclude. All the"Ex's" that his kind would like to do with all that you and I hold sacred. . . Well, this pill might've spooked some of those others whose faith was weak, Brothers and Sisters. But Jesus' General is made of Christian stuff! [GERALD pops the pill. FANNY leads more applause.]

ALBERT: My brother, Gerry, had an unusually large and hard Deus gland.. The Deus pill took its time. ..

FANNY: What is it, Gerald?

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ALBERT AS GERALD: It just dawned on me, Fanny Mae ...How... how... illogical - no, irrational that this all. . . IS ... praying ... Praying is illogical and irrational anytime. .. It is in the same category as speaking to a chair or a shoe... Nobody ever answers a prayer! Ever!

ALBERT: Don't look at me. He insisted on pitting the pill against prayer. I even tried to talk him out of it. I did.

FANNY: ... and that's why I came here today... to save my marriage. After the incident on TV., in front of millions, our whole audience changed... Our program changed.. . Now it's a talk show. Instead of "Jesus" General, it's called "General Mayhem". The guests are gays, transexuals, former convicts, authors, actors, in short, all the rot in the world...

ALBERT: Gerry wants Fanny Mae to loosen up. He wants her to dress up in a garter belt and stockings. He wants her to take her first taste of white wine. He wants her to start watching videos with him.

FANNY: I'm a minister's daughter! I can't do any of those things! They're sinful. They're vulgar. They're cheap. They're beneath me and I ... I ... I ... [ALBERT hands her a Deus-X pill and a glass of water.] But Gerald Spieler is my husband. He's all I had, and now I'm lonely... so lonely that... may God have mercy on my soul. [FANNY takes the pill.]

ALBERT: It didn't take too long before Deus-X shrank Fanny Mae's Deus gland. Fanny Mae now administers to her husband's needs. They invite me for dinner. My brother, Gerry, and I have become best friends. We enjoy good wine and conversation and ... We're attending the Cody execution tonight.

In a nutshell . . . Today I travel all over the world... [He holds up the red Deus-X pill.] I leave it everywhere. As you exit tonight, there'll be a bowl of

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them in the lobby. Take one. They're free. Good night ... Good night and God leave you...

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AWARD HISTORY

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